> when all the courtiers were present in the royal audience hall, each according to his rank, Samad Khan, the grandson of Zal Beg Khan Durrani Baduzai, petitioned that ‘My pension is not being paid.’ His Majesty signalled to the Nizam al-Daula to make an answer, but he merely replied: ‘You lie!’ Samad Khan answered back: ‘It is you who lie! You have humiliated all those who love and are loyal to the royal family.’ Nizam al-Daula, hearing these truthful words, lost his temper and shouted: ‘I’ll have your eyes put out!’ Hearing this boorishness in the royal presence, Samad Khan replied: ‘Were it not that we are in the presence of His Majesty, I would slit your tongue out of your mouth with my sword! We have both lived in this country long enough before the return of His Majesty, and all well know that, while my family have enjoyed high and honourable positions in the state without interruption, you were merely fetching and carrying Mohammad Zaman Khan Barakzai’s pisspot!’

At this point, continued Herati, the Shah rose and left the audience hall, recognising that Samad Khan was indeed one of the highest-born of the Durranis. Nizam al-Daula ‘slunk off to tell his version of events to Macnaghten, who promptly wrote to His Majesty that “Samad Khan is unworthy to remain at court – he must go.” His Majesty considered every order of the English as a command from heaven, and therefore dismissed Samad Khan from court. Consternation covered the Durranis, while the Barakzais crowed in triumph’, exulting in this display of the Shah’s impotence.

Macnaghten took Nizam al-Daula’s advice to reduce particularly the subsidies of the Ghilzai khans on the grounds that ‘They eat up thousands of rupees, all wasted quite unnecessarily: if these are stopped, no one will dare protest!’ However, ‘the Ghilzais did dare protest, and loudly too’, recorded Herati. ‘No ruler has ever, at any time, cut back or abolished our subsidy: we work for it, we guard the roads and the security posts, we restore stolen goods, it is not given to us for nothing and we will not accept any reduction at all!’ The Ghilzais had a point. Since the time of the Mughals, both the Ghilzais and the Khyber and Peshawar tribes had been paid *rahdari* [road keeping] to maintain the road and protect the armies and traders en route to India. The Khattaks kept the road open from the Indus to Peshawar and the Afridis from Peshawar to Jamrud. Every king had paid this subsidy, but now Macnaghten informed the chiefs that he was arbitrarily abrogating this agreement in contravention of customary tribal law and his own written undertakings. To make matters worse, as Herati noted, ‘Nizam al-Daula foolishly refused to hear the complaints of the chiefs, and spoke roughly to them: so they left him and at night, and fled